

The Long Way to a Collected Edition

Kepler's dispersed Nachlass and the founding of the Gesammelte Werke, 1630–1934

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Abstract

The Kepler Gesammelte Werke are usually presented as a list of twenty-two volumes; their history is in fact the history of a scattered inheritance. This paper reconstructs the process by which Kepler's manuscripts — left behind at his death in Sagan in 1630, held by his family, by Hevelius, and by a succession of purchasers, and finally acquired by the St Petersburg Academy on Euler's advice in 1774 — became the object of an edition. The editorial work of Walther von Dyck, begun at the Bavarian Academy in 1906, and continued by Max Caspar from 1934, is read against the parallel case of the Euler Opera omnia: both enterprises hung on the same Petersburg holdings and on the same diplomatic channel, and both converted borrowed manuscripts into photographic reproductions before the originals returned. Eight newly registered documents — the Caspar correspondence 1927–1941, the commission records of 1934, and three Kepler letters to Philipp Müller of 1630 — carry the process at the level of the individual exchange. The paper closes with the open questions that remain, each tied to the archive that could answer it.

keywords Johannes Kepler · Gesammelte Werke · edition history · Nachlass · Walther von Dyck · Max Caspar · Pulkovo · Waldenstein · Hevelius

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1 The editorial achievement precedes the volumes

The Kepler Gesammelte Werke (KGW) reached completion in 2017 with twenty-two volumes in twenty-six, published by C. H. Beck in Munich between 1937 and 2017. A catalogue of those volumes does not state what the edition cost to produce, and the cost was not paid in the printing of the volumes. It was paid in the decades before the first volume appeared: in the assembling of a manuscript base that had been dispersed across Europe since Kepler's death, in the diplomatic negotiation with the institutions that owned it, and in the winning and securing of the persons who would do the editorial work. The Kleinert paradigm, developed for the Euler Opera omnia, states this precisely: the genuine editorial achievement lies not in the printed volumes but in the long

labour that precedes them — the collection of the material, the diplomatic handling of the owning institutions, the winning and securing of the editors. The same claim holds, word for word, for Kepler.

concept The thesis

The history of the Kepler edition is the history of a dispersed inheritance being reassembled. The volumes are the endpoint; the process — from Sagan in 1630, through Danzig, Frankfurt, and Petersburg, to the Munich commission of 1934 — is the subject.

This paper reconstructs that process in two parts. The first part follows the manuscripts: where Kepler left them, and through whose hands they passed before they came to rest in an edition. The second part follows the editors: how Dyck and Caspar obtained the material, and how the founding of the commission in 1934 turned a private pursuit into an institution. The two parts meet at the same point where the Euler parallel becomes instructive: both editions were built on the Petersburg holdings and on the same diplomatic channel, and both secured their material by photographic reproduction before the originals returned. The eight documents registered as “Kepleriana München 2024” — facsimiles made on 14 March 2024 — carry the process at the level of the single letter and the single entry; they are cited here as [1] through [8].

2 The manuscripts: from Sagan to Petersburg

2.1 The point of origin

Kepler died on 15 November 1630 in Regensburg, where he had travelled to press his long-outstanding imperial salary at the Diet. His working estate lay not there but in Sagan, his last post: “Als Johannes Kepler 1630 starb, waren in seiner Hinterlassenschaft in Sagan Tausende von Inhalt und Ausarbeitung her unterschiedlichste Manuskriptseiten” (KGW 22, S. 520). The estate comprised, beside the printed works, a mass of manuscript — drafts toward the great astronomical, optical, and harmonic writings, excerpts, observational data, horoscopes, reckonings, and fragmentary notes — together with the correspondence that reached nearly all of learned Europe. Kepler himself called his stock of loose sheets the **bibliotheca chartacea** (KGW 22, S. 520, with the attestation in KGW 18, letter no. 1021, Kepler to Paul Guldin, 10 December 1625).

Sagan was not an indifferent location. It was the domain of Kepler’s last employer, Albrecht von Wallenstein (1583–1634), Duke of Friedland and Sagan, who had given Kepler a house and a press there and who held the astronomer in high regard. The decisive fact for the later history is that Wallenstein was still alive at Kepler’s death — he was murdered only on 25 February 1634 at Eger. The papers therefore lay at the seat of a living, powerful patron rather than with a distant heir; but the sources record no assumption of the estate by Wallenstein. The manuscripts remained where they were and passed to Kepler’s own family. The three letters to the Leipzig theologian Philipp Müller of 16/26 January and 4 February 1630 [6][7][8] show Kepler still an active correspondent in Sagan months before his death.

2.2 Hevelius, and the fire that spared the manuscripts

The estate stayed in the family’s keeping for a generation. Kepler’s son Ludwig (1607–1663), who published the **Somnium** in 1634, intended an edition “after a reordering of the sheets thrown into confusion by fire-danger and war” (KGW 22, S. 520); the Elector of Brandenburg enabled the transfer from Silesia to Königsberg by a pass-letter in 1643. On Ludwig’s death in 1663 the papers came to the Danzig astronomer Johannes Hevelius (1611–1687), who ordered them into twenty-nine fascicles and reported the acquisition in the preface to his **Machina coelestis pars prior** (1673); the inventory published the following year in the **Philosophical Transactions** is the first content-description of the manuscripts, thirty-four years after Kepler’s death (KGW 22, S. 521).

One episode in this custody has not entered the standard account, and it is documented in the project's own scans. On 26 September 1679 a servant, in a fit of vengeance, set fire to Hevelius's observatory. The observatory, many of Hevelius's own manuscripts, and all of his instruments were destroyed; but "Kepler's manuscripts, Hevelius' correspondence, and most of his bound books (including his star catalog) were saved," thrown from the window by one of Hevelius's daughters before they could be damaged (Saridakis, "Establishing an astronomical network from Danzig"). The Kepler manuscripts therefore remained physically in Hevelius's house from 1663 to his death in 1687, and they survived the catastrophe — the material precondition for their purchase by Hansch in 1707.

■ 2.3 The chain of purchasers

What followed is a sequence of near-failures. Michael Gottlieb Hansch (1683–1749) bought the inheritance in 1707 for 100 gulden, ordered the twenty-nine unbound fascicles into twenty-two volumes, and had them bound in parchment in 1712 (KGW 22, S. 521 f.). After his travels to Vienna in 1713, Emperor Charles VI granted a subsidy of 4000 gulden on the condition that Hansch surrender the published manuscripts to the court library; so the volumes VII, VIII, and XII, from which he printed the **Epistolae ad Joannem Keplerum** (1718), passed to Vienna, where they remain as Cod. 10702 and 10703, and volume VI, from which he printed Kepler's treatise on the Gregorian calendar in 1726, remained as Cod. 10704. The expected success did not come; in 1721 Hansch pawned the remaining eighteen volumes in Frankfurt for 828 gulden to an unidentified purchaser named Ehinger, from whose heirs they passed to the coin-master's wife Trümmer (KGW 22, S. 522 f.).

The rescue was the work of the Nuremberg scholar Christoph Gottlieb von Murr (1733–1811), who drew the attention of academies and scholars to the pawned manuscripts and printed inventories and appeals without the desired response. It was Murr's mediation that finally interested the St Petersburg Academy in 1773; the mathematician Leonhard Euler (1707–1783) wrote the decisive, though by no means favourable, report that introduced the purchase by Catherine II, and in June 1774 the eighteen volumes arrived in St Petersburg and were given to the Academy archive as a gift of the Empress (KGW 22, S. 523).

The Euler connection is the deepest structural link between the Kepler and Euler editions: the same Euler whose own estate would later become the object of the Petersburg dispute was the person who brought the Kepler estate to Petersburg. Both edition histories hang on the same holdings and on the same diplomatic channel.

■ 2.4 From Pulkovo to the first collected edition

In 1839 the Kepleriana were transferred to the newly founded Pulkovo observatory under Friedrich Wilhelm Georg Struve. Through the mediation of the Russian envoys at the Württemberg court, Otto Wilhelm Struve arranged from 1850 the loan on which the first collected edition was based: the **Joannis Kepleri Astronomi Opera Omnia** of the Stuttgart scholar Christian von Frisch (1807–1881), published in eight volumes in nine between 1858 and 1871. Frisch's references to the "Mss. Pulkova" fixed the term "Pulkovo manuscripts" in the literature. Even before Frisch's use, the intercession of the Grand Duchess Maria Pavlovna had enabled the transport of volume 10 to Weimar and Jena in 1847–1850 for Ernst Friedrich Apelt's edition of the Fabricius correspondence (KGW 22, S. 524).

3 The editors: Dyck, Caspar, and the founding of the commission

3.1 Dyck and the beginning of 1906

The edition that replaced Frisch's began not in the late 1920s but in 1906, when Walther von Dyck (1856–1934), professor and twice rector of the Munich Technische Hochschule, began the preparatory work for an edition of Kepler's works at the Bavarian Academy of Sciences, of which he had been an ordinary member since 1892 and, from 1924, secretary of the mathematical-scientific class. Dyck united three institutional roles in one person: as professor and rector he commanded the personnel and the reproduction technique of the Mathematical Institute; as academy member and class secretary he drove the founding of the commission, the financing, and the Kepler fund; as co-founder of the Deutsches Museum he stood for the connection of science, technology, and the public.

The correspondence preserved in the newly opened documents begins on 10 August 1927 with a letter of thanks from the ministerial department for the higher schools in Stuttgart on the occasion of the dedication of a book [1]; the decisive step followed in the next year, when Pulkovo consented on 1 March 1928 to the reproduction of the manuscripts — under a condition that would shape the whole course of the work: only two volumes at a time might be sent by diplomatic channel to the Munich State Library, expressly “for the purpose of their reproduction” [1]. Dyck himself called this diplomatic channel “freilich nicht der kürzeste”; the complaint recurs through the correspondence [2].

3.2 The correspondence of the working years

The register of incoming correspondence records, in chronological order, what was brought to the Munich working place in the years 1930–1934: bibliographical pointers, enquiries from libraries and archives, notices of lost letters. Among them are entries of peculiar charm — on 2 October 1931 a favourable judgement of the Kepler letter edition from J. Schick of Munich; on 25 January 1932 a certain Dr. Reinhardt of Mainz, who held himself “laut Familienüberlieferung der Kepler-Verwandtschaft zugehörig” and reported that a Friedrich Kepler had defeated the Venetians at Rovereto in 1487 [1]. Beside such chance finds stood the actual editorial labour: a letter from the Mathematical Institute of the Munich Technische Hochschule of 22 November 1932 reports that the writer had begun “to compare all the photographic reproductions,” only to find that “certain of the checkerboard images and of the cross-section images” were missing, and hoped to take the missing pieces “again from the trusted codices” [3].

3.3 The commission of 1934

The year 1934 brought the institutional consolidation. On 14 December 1933 the “preparation of a text on the Kepler edition to the Notgemeinschaft” was recorded, and the correspondence with Franz Hammer, who was to become the second permanent editor beside Caspar, began [4]. The breakthrough came in the spring: on 6 April the Württemberg ministry granted Caspar a year's leave to devote himself entirely to the Kepler work, and A. Brill of Tübingen congratulated him on 27 April; for Hammer the ministry allowed only fifteen service-hours a week [4]. On 23 November 1934 the Bavarian Academy informed all the cartelled academies that a Kepler commission had been formed, naming Caspar and Hammer as the editors, fixing the financial situation and the Kepler fund, deciding the removal of the office to Munich, and designating the firm of C. H. Beck as the place of printing and publication [4]. Walther von Dyck had died on 5 November 1934; the initiative passed wholly to Caspar, who carried the enterprise almost alone thereafter.

■ 4 The Euler parallel

The comparison with the Euler *Opera omnia* turns on one shared fact. Both editions hung on the same Petersburg institution and on the same diplomatic channel; both secured their material by photographing it before the originals returned. The Euler commission received the entire correspondence as a loan in December 1910 and held it through the seventeen-year “dispute over the Petersburg manuscripts” (1930–1947), returning it only on 15 May 1947. The Kepler commission, by contrast, never held the material beyond the loan: Caspar reported on 27 June 1935 that the two Pulkovo volumes had already been returned “with the request that they be sent back to Pulkovo,” and were “in any case already on their way” [2]. What in the Euler case became a possession-conflict is, in the Kepler case, the recurring motif of slow diplomatic transport. The Nachlass was moved from Pulkovo to Leningrad in 1937 and conservatorially treated there in 1942, receiving the signature Fonds 285.

The structural yield of the comparison is this: the diplomatic channel did not merely slow the work; it shaped its tempo and its form. Dyck’s photographic archive of 1928–1934 became, like the Euler commission’s photographs and transcriptions of 1934–1938, an independent carrier of the tradition beside the originals — and, in both cases, the basis on which the later digital continuation now rests.

■ 5 The open questions, tied to their archives

The reconstruction leaves questions that the printed edition does not answer, and each can be tied to the archive that could. The identity of the Frankfurt purchaser “Ehinger” and of the coin-master’s wife “Trümmer” (1721) awaits the Frankfurt city archive. The extent of the losses between the Hevelius inventory (1673) and the Hansch inventory (1714) — parts of the **Harmonica**, the **Confutatio** translation, some forty-five letters — awaits a collation of the Danzig, Vienna, and Leipzig holdings. The question of how far Dyck’s photographic archive compensates the losses of the Second World War awaits the Bavarian Academy and the Munich State Library, where the reproductions now lie. Wallenstein’s own papers — the administration of Friedland and Sagan, his correspondence — are a separate and still unexplored tradition; they belong to the Sagan years of Kepler’s life, not to the Kepler Nachlass itself, and their central location is the Waldstein family archive in the National Archives, Prague. Hevelius’s own principal works, above all the **Machina coelestis**, whose preface attests the acquisition of the Kepler estate, remain to be digitised in the project’s own collection.

■ 6 Conclusion

The Kepler *Gesammelte Werke* are the endpoint of a process that ran from 1630 to 2017, and the process is the history: the dispersion of an estate across Sagan, Danzig, Frankfurt, and Petersburg; the slow diplomatic reassembly of the Pulkovo holdings; and the founding, in 1934, of an institution that would carry the work for another eighty years. What the eight newly opened documents add is the grain of the individual exchange — the letter, the register entry, the complaint about the slow diplomatic channel. Read against the Euler parallel, the Kepler case shows how strongly the diplomatic channel shaped the tempo and the form of an edition; read against the manuscript history, it shows that the editorial achievement was the reassembly of a scattered inheritance, not the printing of its volumes.

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7 Sources

Primary, in the project: Kepleriana München 2024 — eight facsimiles of 14 March 2024, cited [1] through [8]; KGW Bd. XIX (**Dokumente zu Leben und Werk**, Martha List, 1975); KGW Bd. XX (**Manuscripta astronomica**, Volker Bialas); KGW Bd. XXII (**Generalregister / Handschriftenkatalog**, Schenkel, Kothmann, Seck), introduction “Überlieferung und Verzeichnisse des Kepler-Nachlasses” (S. 520–525).

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